ships for the attack.[6]

Edward the Black Prince—aged twenty-six, a ten-year veteran of the war with the French—was in his father's territory of Gascony; from there, he had been leading raids into Languedoc, raiding and killing, burning French towns and villages, Toulouse among them. In August 1356, while John was in Normandy fighting the Navarrese and English, Edward marched out of Gascony, towards the Loire river, with eight thousand men.[7]

The march was another large-scale raid, not necessarily meant to force John II into a showdown: "It was our purpose to ride forth against the enemies in the parts of France," the Black Prince himself wrote, ". . . harrying and wasting the country." But John II turned to meet Edward, and the two armies came face-to-face at Poitiers. The French, better rested and better organized, had every reason to expect victory.

On September 19, the English army drove back the French, a pattern that was rapidly becoming embarrassing for the French cause. Thomas Gray accuses the French generals of failing to act together because they "were at variance because of bitter words"; other accounts suggest that John II's decision to have his knights dismount and fight on foot after the initial charge —an attempt to avoid the English archers who had been so deadly in the past —caused the disaster.[8]

